

the state at large may entertain from foreign-interest-laden proprietary closed source software.”

In the petition, the members of the community members have demanded:

- Declare and implement a FOSS policy at least along the lines of the policy adopted in Kerala, and certainly beyond the minimal policy lines in the central government policy.
- Try to understand the concept of ‘vendor neutrality and open standards’, and follow it in all dealings. All e-governance projects should be built on open platforms, following open standards. Taxpayers’ money should not be spent in buying software licences, bringing vendor lock-in and a host of evils in public services.
- Revive bodies like WB-IOTA (that have not been witnessing much activity since the formation of the present government), and also form similar bodies to oversee the adoption of FOSS in all spheres of activity.

A. Mani, the coordinator of the LUG, said, “The technical superiority of free and open source software is proven. Most of the Internet giants like Amazon, Facebook, Google, Twitter and Yahoo use free software to run their applications and infrastructure. In Microsoft’s own land, the Obama administration is going in for free software as the means of delivering e-governance. Government departments are known to be the largest consumers of software, and a short-

sighted policy of this kind is bound to have serious adverse effects—beyond the wastage of taxpayers’ money. It is also never too late to make amends.”

The petition was submitted on December 3, 2011, to both the secretaries and minister in charge of IT, government of West Bengal. Mani said, “We have not heard from them. Obviously, we do not intend to sit and watch. We intend to apply pressure through all quarters, including the central government. This is important, since not many people are keen to take up the cause openly, due to political vendetta unleashed by the present state government.”

GLUG members also plan to go the RTI way to get more background information on this deal with Microsoft and check for shady connotations.

It is worth mentioning here that the Tamil Nadu government had to take its anti-open source steps back in the case of distribution of free laptops, because of a similar movement.

The effort is to promote free and open source software, which in a way saves the money of the citizens, which they deposit with the state as ‘tax’. The new West Bengal state government could have tried better policies to attract Microsoft’s investment, rather than offering perks on a platter. **END** 

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